selling vacuum cleaners! I got exposed to the Scandinavian socialist economic model, where the government encouraged free market policies but also ensured a basic standard of living and a level playing field for everyone.

After completing my BCom degree with a top 10 rank in Mumbai University, I joined IIM Calcutta for an MBA programme. In the meanwhile, I had secured admission and a scholarship to INSEAD, one of the leading business schools in the world. After a term at IIM, I left for France. After graduating at the top of my class, I was offered highly paid jobs in the USA, France and Sweden, but chose to return to India and acquire a solid foundation in banking and finance.

I started my banking career in the current accounts department of Grindlays Bank in Kolkata. The hours were punishingly long since the entire operation was manual. In addition, I had to deal with seven aggressive trade unions and their several members who worked in my department. It was a trial by fire, but it gave me a thorough grounding in banking and taught me what management was truly about. When I started to learn Bengali, the doors of communication with my team opened, as they appreciated the effort more than my knowledge of the language.

I grew to be the Planning Officer for eastern India, and led the first wave of computerization for the bank's eastern region. But I wanted to be an investment banker, and so joined one of the best merchant bankers in the country. This was the era when India was just beginning to welcome foreign investment. In addition to foreign currency loan syndications and equity offerings, I specialized in advising multinational corporations on how to enter India. Working closely with the ministries of finance, commerce and industry, I secured approval for the first foreign investment into the financial services industry in India – that of the investment bank Lazard.

I owe a great deal to my boss in this organization, for he not only gave me a grounding in investment banking and corporate finance, but also allowed me to work flexible hours, enabling me to fulfil my duties